

Trying to keep track of how much screen time your kid actually gets

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 4 sources · cheatgrid.com

You just said a number. It's for your kid's screen time, and some part of you would rather not check it, because being wrong might mean you haven't been paying attention.

THE GOAL

You want a number for your kid's screen time you can trust, not one you're just repeating because it sounds about right.

CHECKLIST

You've just said a number out loud, or in your head, for how much screen time your kid gets.

- ☐ Write down the number you just said, before you second-guess it.
- ☐ Note which activities you meant by your number (games, videos, texting, calls), so you know what you actually counted.
- ☐ Open the usage report built into your kid's main device, and read its total for the period you guessed about.
- ☐ If your kid also games or watches on a console, tablet, or shared TV, **check that device too**: a phone's report won't include it.
- ☐ Keep the two device numbers separate rather than adding them from memory, so you know which is which.
- ☐ When asking your kid for their own number, **name yesterday specifically** instead of asking what's typical.
- ☐ Ask your kid what they did in each chunk of time, not just the total minutes, so a video call doesn't get filed as gaming.
- ☐ Set schoolwork or homework screen time aside as its own line, separate from everything else.
- ☐ If comparing your number to a guideline or another parent's, check whether it **counts school time** the same way yours does.
- ☐ Compare today's number with the last one you wrote down, before comparing it to anyone else's figure.
- ☐ Save today's number somewhere you'll see it again, dated, so you're not starting from a guess next time.
- ☐ Pick one moment each week to check the report again, so next time's number is measured, not remembered.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Your number for your kid's screen time is probably wrong, and it's not always an underestimate.
- 2 Your miss runs high or low depending on how much your kid already uses a screen.
- 3 Parents' guesses run backwards on the mix. They go too high on texting and calls, **too low** on gaming and social apps.

Your own number is shakier than it feels

KNOW

Your number for your kid's screen time is probably wrong, and it's not always an underestimate.

Seven in ten parents in a preschooler study were off, split almost evenly between guessing **too high and too low**. [Source 1](#)

RULE

Your miss runs high or low depending on how much your kid already uses a screen.

Parents of preschoolers guessed high when logged use was under an hour a day, and low at an hour or more. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

This study's screen-time number for teens didn't include schoolwork, and if you count the same way, yours probably doesn't either.

This study's own screen-time total left out schoolwork, so the researchers say the real total is likely higher than what they reported. [Source 3](#)

DO

Ask your kid about the last few days, not a typical day or the past year: the longer the memory, the more it drifts from what happened.

Teens' reports over three weeks lined up with objective tracking, but their year-long guesses did not. [Source 4](#)

A matching number doesn't mean a matching measurement

KNOW

There's **no agreed definition** of 'screen time', so a matching number might be counting more, or less, than yours does.

Even researchers can't agree on what to count as screen use, so a guideline's number and yours can mean different things. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

A clear number for your kid's screen time doesn't exist: researchers still don't agree how to count time spent across several screens at once, so a rough trend works better than an exact figure.

Nobody has agreed on how to score using a phone, a TV, and a laptop in the same stretch of time. [Source 2](#)

You're probably wrong about the mix, not just the total

KNOW

Parents' guesses run backwards on the mix. They go too high on texting and calls, **too low** on gaming and social apps.

Parents reported more of their teen's texting and video chats, and less of their gaming and social media, than teens said about themselves. [Source 3](#)

WATCH

A device's own usage report only shows what happens on that device: most gaming happens elsewhere, so a phone-only number makes gaming look far smaller than it is.

Teens said only about a third of their own gaming time actually happened on their phone. [Source 4](#)

Sources

1. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7329252/>
2. <https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7277381/>
3. [https://www.academicpedsjnl.net/article/S1876-2859\(21\)00623-9/fulltext](https://www.academicpedsjnl.net/article/S1876-2859(21)00623-9/fulltext)
4. <https://www.nature.com/articles/s44184-025-00131-z>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Children and screens at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)